boiling point. The pot finally exploded on 6 October 1973, when, hoping to snatch back territory lost to Israel in 1967, Egyptian and Syrian troops launched a coordinated attack against the Jewish state on Yom Kippur, the holiest day on the Jewish calendar.

Writing on 10 October to Syria's President Hafez al-Assad, Honecker stated that 'for the righteous fight, which your people fight against the aggressor and for the liberation of the territory occupied by Israel, the GDR will always provide active support'.3 Despite the First Secretary's limitless and affectionate devotion to Assad's cause, the Syrian campaign was a disaster from the outset. While Egyptian troops swept into the Sinai Peninsula, Assad's forces struggled to drive the occupying Israelis out of the Golan Heights, leading to a humiliating ceasefire at the end of October.

Showing solidarity with the deflated Syrian leader, Honecker arranged a vast shipment of military equipment be delivered to Damascus from the GDR. 'The people of the German Democratic Republic, together with the people of the Soviet Union and other countries of the socialist community, support, as always, those countries and peoples who fight for freedom and independence,' Honecker wrote in a personal letter to Assad on 3 November 1973.4 He then listed a staggering array of military hardware shipped from East Berlin to Damascus, including a squadron of twelve interceptor MiG-21 fighters, sixty-two 'T-54 AM' Soviet battle tanks with ammunition, 720,000 rounds of machine-gun bullets, 3,600 hand grenades, 3,300 bazookas and 30,000 'TM-46' anti-tank mines. 'The government of the German Democratic Republic,' Honecker concluded, 'are convinced that this support will contribute to the success of the righteous fight of the people of the Syrian Arab Republic, fighting for freedom and independence, and assure you, Excellency, of their ongoing solidarity.'5 Though Assad's cup ranneth over with deadly foreign hardware, it soon became clear his chronically weak army faced an unmitigated disaster. From the beginning, Israeli troops shelled targets in Damascus, including the Defence Ministry, the headquarters of the General Staff, the Air Force command centre and oil refineries and power stations in central Syria. To make matters worse, when the Egyptian-Israeli ceasefire exposed Syria to defeat, Israel snatched even more territory in the Golan Heights.